WhatsApp Business API – Step-by-Step Setup Guide

Using Meta's official WhatsApp Cloud API (directly – no third-party provider) · Prepared for the clinic · Information checked against Meta's official pages on 30 October 2026

In one line: the clinic gets a verified Meta business account, a WhatsApp business number and a website with a Privacy Policy; we connect our software to Meta's WhatsApp Cloud API so messages (appointment reminders, confirmations, replies) go out from the clinic's own WhatsApp number.

1 Requirements → 2 Website ready → 3 Meta business account → 4 Business verification → 5 Domain (if needed) → 6 App + WhatsApp account → 7 Phone number → 8 Payment → 9 Access token → 10 Webhook → 11 Templates → 12 Test & go live

Client = the clinic does this Us = our team does this Together = done on a call / screen-share

1. Requirements – what the client provides

#	Item	Details
1	**Business phone number**	Used for Meta's business verification (Meta may send a code to it). Can be the same as the WhatsApp number.
2	**Website (live)**	Shows the clinic name, phone, email and address. **Must have a Privacy Policy page** (required by WhatsApp's Business Policy). Terms & Conditions page recommended. Meta's business account form asks for a website by default.
3	**Business certificates**	E.g. Udyam/MSME certificate, GST certificate, clinic/shop registration. Business name and address on them must match what we enter with Meta. Up to **3 documents, max 5 MB each, PDF/JPG/PNG**.
4	**WhatsApp phone number**	Preferably a mobile. Must **not currently be on WhatsApp** (normal or Business app) and must receive an SMS or call for the code.
5	**Owner's Facebook login**	The owner's personal Facebook account, used to create the Meta business account and add our team. **No Facebook Page is needed.**
6	**Business email**	Best: an email ending with the website name (e.g. `info@yourclinic.com`) – Meta can send the verification code there. If only Gmail exists, we verify by phone or website (domain) instead.
7	**Website domain access**	Access to the domain's DNS settings, or the web developer's contact – to add one verification line if needed. No password has to be shared with us.
8	**Payment card**	Added to the WhatsApp account so Meta can bill paid messages.
9	**Display name, logo, description**	The clinic name patients will see on WhatsApp, a square logo and a short description for the profile.

10	**Patient permission (opt-in)**	Patients must agree to receive WhatsApp messages (e.g. a consent line on the registration form). Meta requires this.

2. How the accounts are set up (recommended for one clinic)

- **The clinic owns everything:** the Meta business account, the WhatsApp account, the phone number and the developer app all belong to the clinic.
- **Our team is added inside the clinic's account** (as admin/developer) and sets everything up there.
- Why: if *our own* company's app accessed WhatsApp accounts owned by other businesses, Meta requires "Advanced access" (App Review) – the Tech Provider route. Keeping the app in the clinic's own account avoids that. Meta also only lets a WhatsApp account be shared with a *verified* partner business.
- If later we serve many clinics from one platform, we can apply to become a Meta **Tech Provider**.

3. Step-by-step

Step 1 – Get the website ready Client

- Website is live and opens on `https://`.
- Shows the clinic name, phone, email and address (the address can be the actual clinic address – it doesn't have to be the MSME address).
- Add a **Privacy Policy** page: what patient data is collected (name, phone), why (appointments, reminders), that messages are sent via WhatsApp, and how to stop messages.
- Add a **Terms & Conditions** page (recommended).

Step 2 – Create the Meta business account ("business portfolio") Together

1. The owner logs in with Facebook at `business.facebook.com` and creates a business portfolio (or picks an existing one).
2. Fill in **Business info**: legal business name, address, phone and website – **exactly as on the certificate** we will upload.
3. Add our team members under **Users** → **People** with admin access.

Step 3 – Business verification Together

1. In the business portfolio settings, start **Business verification** (Meta's menu names can change slightly).
2. Confirm the business details and **upload the certificates** (max 3, ≤ 5 MB each, PDF/JPG/PNG).
3. Choose how Meta confirms contact:
   - **Email** – code to an email on the website's domain (e.g. info@yourclinic.com). Gmail is not accepted for this.
   - **Phone** – code by call/SMS to the business phone number.
   - **Domain** – prove the website belongs to the clinic (see Step 4).
4. Enter the code. Status shows **Pending**, then **Verified** once Meta approves.

Meta does not publish a fixed review time for standard verification. Until verified, the account works with low limits (see Step 12).

Step 4 – Domain verification (only if needed) Client + Us

1. We add the clinic's website domain in the business portfolio settings (usually under **Brand safety → Domains**).
2. Meta gives a verification code. Meta's two methods: add a **DNS TXT record**, or upload a small **HTML file** to the website.
3. The clinic (or its web developer) adds it – no password shared with us.
4. We click **Verify**. DNS changes can take a little while to show.

Step 5 – Create the developer app and WhatsApp account Us

1. At `developers.facebook.com` → **My Apps** → **Create app**, choose the **WhatsApp** use case and select the clinic's business portfolio.
2. In the app's **WhatsApp → API Setup**, click **Create a WhatsApp Business account** (or select an existing one).

   Alternative: Business settings → Accounts → WhatsApp accounts → +Add → Create a new WhatsApp account.
3. Fill in the app's basic settings (app name, contact email, privacy policy URL, etc.).

Step 6 – Add and verify the WhatsApp phone number Together

1. Make sure the number is **not on WhatsApp**. If it is on the WhatsApp Business app, delete that account in the app first (keeping both at once – "Coexistence" – is only possible through a Meta partner).
2. In API Setup, click **Add phone number**: enter the **display name** (clinic name), category and the number with country code (+91).
3. Meta sends a code by **SMS or voice call** – the clinic reads it out, we enter it.
4. We register the number with Meta's servers (set a 6-digit PIN for two-step verification).

Rules from Meta: the number must be owned by the business, have a country/area code (short codes not supported) and receive SMS or calls. Mobile is recommended. New business accounts can register 2 numbers at first (20 after verification). The display name is reviewed automatically and can be changed up to 10 times in 30 days.

Step 7 – Add the payment method Client

Add the card to the WhatsApp account's payment settings (in WhatsApp Manager / billing). Meta bills paid messages to it.

Step 8 – Permanent access token (the "key" for our software) Us

1. Business settings → **Users** → **System users** → **Add** (admin system user).
2. Assign it the **app** and the **WhatsApp account**.
3. **Generate token** with WhatsApp permissions (`whatsapp_business_messaging`, `whatsapp_business_management`).
4. Store the token securely on our server only – never in the website or the app's code shown to users.

The temporary token shown in API Setup expires quickly – Meta says to create a permanent (system user) token.

Step 9 – Webhook (so we receive patients' replies) Us

1. Our server has an endpoint with a valid SSL certificate (`https://` ; self-signed certificates are not accepted).
2. In the app: **WhatsApp** → **Configuration**, enter the callback URL and a **verify token** we choose. Meta sends a check request; our server replies with Meta's challenge value.
3. Subscribe to the fields `messages` (incoming messages and delivery status) and `message_template_status_update` (template approved/rejected).

Step 10 – Create message templates Us + client approves wording

- Templates are needed to **start** a conversation (e.g. reminders). Inside the 24-hour window after a patient writes, normal replies can be sent.
- Only **3 categories**: **Utility** (appointment confirmations/reminders – must not be promotional), **Marketing** (offers, check-up campaigns), **Authentication** (OTP codes only).
- Parts: **body** (required, up to 1024 characters, variables like `{{1}}`), optional **header**, optional **footer** (max 60 characters), optional **buttons** (up to 10 in total: quick replies, max 2 website buttons, max 1 call button).
- Give an **example value for every variable**. Meta reviews within **up to 24 hours**.

> **Example (Utility):** "Hello {{1}}, this is a reminder of your appointment at {{2}} on {{3}} at {{4}}. Reply YES to confirm or call us to reschedule."
> Example values: Riya Sharma · Dental Metrix · 05/11/2026 · 10:30 AM

Step 11 – Connect our software and test Us

1. Our system sends messages through Meta's API: `POST https://graph.facebook.com/v26.0/{phone-number-id}/messages` (v26.0 is the latest version today; old versions like v17.0 have expired).
2. Send test templates to our own numbers, check delivery, replies and the webhook.
3. Check opt-in is recorded for every patient before messaging.

Step 12 – Go live and grow the limits Together

- **Messaging limit:** a new account can message **250 different people per 24 hours**. It rises step by step (2,000 → 10,000 → 100,000 → unlimited) after business verification, or after 2,000 good-quality template messages in 30 days.
- **Quality:** if many patients block or report messages, Meta lowers the quality rating and can limit the account. Send only expected, useful messages.
- Unverified accounts are also limited to 250 templates; verified accounts with an approved display name get up to 6,000.

4. Cost (how Meta charges)

Rule	Details (per Meta's pricing page, Oct 2026)
Charged per message	Since 1 July 2025 Meta charges **per delivered message** (not per conversation). Messages patients send to the clinic are free.
Price depends on	Message category (Marketing / Utility / Authentication / Service) and the patient's country (India rates on Meta's rate card).
Normal replies ("service")	Each phone number gets **1,000 free service messages per month** (from 1 October 2026); beyond that they are charged.
Utility templates	Charged (from 1 October 2026 also inside the 24-hour window). Volume discounts apply for utility and authentication.
Chats started from ads / Page buttons	A free window of up to 7 days.
Our setup cost	No third-party provider fees – only Meta's message charges plus our service.

Exact India rates: see the rate card linked on Meta's pricing page – rates change, so check before quoting.

5. Important rules (to avoid the account being blocked)

- **Opt-in first:** only message patients who agreed to WhatsApp messages.
- **Privacy Policy** published on the website (WhatsApp Business Policy).
- **Templates outside 24 hours:** to start a conversation or message after 24 hours, use an approved template.
- **Correct category:** reminders = Utility; offers = Marketing. Meta can re-classify a wrongly labelled template.
- **Same details everywhere:** business name/address/phone in Meta must match the certificates.
- **WhatsApp profile** must show contact information (email, website and/or phone).

6. Timeline

Meta does not publish a fixed timeline. In practice: website and documents ready → business account and verification (the longest part, varies) → app, number, token and webhook (about a day of work) → templates (review up to 24 hours) → testing → live.

Please double-check in Meta (pages that need a browser login): Meta's exact list of accepted Indian documents, the exact verification-email rule and the display-name guidelines are on Meta's Business Help Center, which could not be read automatically: facebook.com/business/help/159334372093366 (documents) · …/1095661473946872 (verification) · …/757569725593362 (display name).

7. Sources (Meta official)

Pricing – developers.facebook.com/docs/whatsapp/pricing · Templates – developers.facebook.com/docs/whatsapp/business-management-api/message-templates (and /components) · Template review – developers.facebook.com/documentation/business-messaging/whatsapp/templates/template-review · Webhooks – developers.facebook.com/docs/whatsapp/cloud-api/guides/set-up-webhooks · Access tokens – developers.facebook.com/documentation/business-messaging/whatsapp/access-tokens · Get started – developers.facebook.com/docs/whatsapp/cloud-api/get-started · Phone numbers –

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